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Examination Integrity in India: Analysing the Role of Political Influence, Governance Deficits, and Institutional Weaknesses in Examination Paper Leaks

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ABSTRACT

Introduction:

India has one of the oldest and largest education system and competitive examinations , Board etc plays a very crucial role in it.But when these papers are leaked, cheated and re- conducted these not only not affect the integrity of the Indian Education System but also affects Hard work done by the aspirants. The hard work of 12-15 hours of the aspirants , the resources used by them are just wasted due to Political Corruption and a leak. This study examines how political influence, governance deficits, corruption, and institutional weaknesses integrity in India.

Re-conduction of the exams not only doesn't affect aspirants' hard work and resources but also Government extra financial resources are used .

Methodology:

The study is based on two main Sources - Primary and secondary data

The primary data is the survey through google forms given to more than 80 people out of which More than half (62%) are school students and 17-18% were college students and remaining are working people like Lawyers, houseworker etc

The secondary data was based on existing researches on this topic.the Data was taken from different Government sites,news articles and Previous research papers

Result:

The findings indicate that a majority of respondents view examination paper leaks as a serious threat to fairness and believe that political influence, corruption, and weak governance contribute to such incidents. Secondary data further show that paper leaks affect millions of candidates, impose significant economic costs, and undermine public trust in examination systems.

Conclusion:

The study concludes that examination paper leaks are not merely educational failures but also governance challenges linked to corruption, weak accountability, and institutional shortcomings. Both primary and secondary data indicate that such incidents undermine meritocracy, reduce public trust, and impose significant social and economic costs. Strengthening examination security, transparency, and institutional accountability is essential to ensure fairness and protect the integrity of India's education system.

Keywords: *Examination integrity, Paper leaks, Governance, Political influence, Public Examinations Act 2024, Competitive examinations, India*

1. INTRODUCTION

India's education system is one of the largest education systems in the world, and one of the most important components in the Indian Education System is competitive exams and Boards. It is estimated that almost 70 million people appear for competitive exams annually, out of which only a fraction of students get selected for top institutions, which makes these exams important and challenging.

More than 25% of students take a drop year or opt for dummy schooling just for preparation for competitive examinations.Students invest significant financial resources in coaching centers, aspiring to join prestigious colleges . However, the integrity of the education system has been severely compromised by repeated paper leaks, which makes these high-stakes examinations even more unfair and undermines meritocracy, social mobility, and the constitutional right to equal educational opportunities in India, With more than 70+ paper leaks reported across 15 states in past 7 years has affected more than 1.5 cr students annually.

The most recent and major instances include the TWO NEET(2024,2026)paper leaks and the SSC CGL paper leak where the question paper was getting sold between the range of 30 thousand to 30 lakh. Which resulted in 67 students scoring perfect in NEET 2024. These incidents are just not only normal failure but Symptoms of political corruption and governance failure in India's education system. Despite of the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024—which prescribes imprisonment of 3–10 years and fines up to ₹1 crore—few top officials have faced action in the 45 major paper leak cases investigated between 2002 and 2025.

"The decay of institutions begins when rules are bent to serve power rather than to constrain it." — Douglass North

This observation captures the central dilemma confronting examination systems in contemporary India. Educational examinations, designed as neutral instruments for the allocation of merit and opportunity, are increasingly embedded within broader structures of political power and governance failures. The integrity of these systems is therefore not merely an administrative concern but a reflection of deeper institutional and political dynamics.

1.1 The Significance of Examination Integrity

Examination systems in India function as critical gatekeeping institutions that regulate access to higher education, employment, and social mobility. In a society characterized by demographic pressure and limited high-quality opportunities, examinations such as NEET, UPSC, and state-level recruitment tests acquire extraordinary socio-economic importance. Consequently, their credibility underpins the very idea of meritocracy and equal opportunity.

However, repeated instances of paper leaks, organized cheating, and procedural manipulation have raised fundamental questions regarding the reliability of these systems. The erosion of examination integrity does not merely disadvantage individual candidates; it undermines public trust in state institutions, distorts human capital allocation, and weakens the legitimacy of democratic governance. Thus, the issue assumes significance not only within the domain of education but also within the broader framework of political economy and institutional theory.

1.2 Defining the Problem

This paper conceptualizes "examination integrity" as a composite of fairness, transparency, accountability, and procedural security within assessment systems. The problem under investigation is not limited to isolated incidents of malpractice but extends to a systemic pattern characterized by recurring failures across different regions and examination bodies.

At its core, the problem represents a form of institutional erosion, wherein formal rules and regulatory mechanisms exist but are inconsistently implemented. This results in a divergence between the intended functioning of institutions and their actual outcomes. Such divergence reflects what scholars describe as a "governance deficit," where the capacity of the state to enforce rules and ensure accountability remains limited.

Importantly, this study treats examination malpractice not as a purely educational issue but as a manifestation of broader structural conditions, including corruption, bureaucratic inefficiency, and political interference.

1.3 Mechanisms Linking Politics, Governance and Integrity

The central argument of this paper is that examination integrity in India is shaped by the interaction of political incentives and governance structures. This relationship can be understood through the lens of institutional economics and political economy.

First, weak governance frameworks create opportunities for rent-seeking behavior, where actors within and outside the system exploit informational asymmetries for private gain. Examination systems, characterized by high stakes and limited opportunities, become fertile ground for such activities.

Second, political incentives often discourage strict enforcement of rules. In democratic contexts, where electoral considerations dominate, long-term institutional reforms are frequently subordinated to short-term political calculations. This results in selective enforcement, regulatory capture, and the persistence of corruption networks.

Third, the principal-agent problem further complicates governance. Examination authorities (agents), entrusted with implementing rules, operate with significant discretion and limited oversight, enabling deviations from prescribed norms. In the absence of effective accountability mechanisms, such deviations become normalized.

Finally, the interplay between formal institutions and informal networks—comprising political patronage, economic influence, and social connections—creates a parallel system of power that undermines the rule-based functioning of examination bodies

1.4 Research Orientation

Against this backdrop, the present study seeks to analyze the impact of politics and governance on examination integrity in India by addressing three core questions:

1. Why has examination malpractice emerged as a persistent and systemic issue?
2. What institutional and governance failures characterize this phenomenon?
3. How do political incentives and structural conditions sustain and reproduce these failures over time?

Table-1: Major Recent Examination Paper Leaks in India

Paper Name	Year	State/s	What Happened	Aftermath
NEET-UG	2026	Bihar,Gujarat	Question paper was leaked in advance with more than 22 lakh students affected . It was done by a printing press in maharashtra and later scanned in Sikar, rajasthan	-Exam Cancelled -Protests -CBI raids expanded and done all over India -Multiple arrests made -Security tightened for future examinations
NEET-UG	2024	Bihar, Gujarat, Jharkhand	CBI alleged leak originated from Oasis school hazaribagh and 67 students scored 720/720	-Supreme court declared undisputed fact -67 students disqualified -Arrests made to official and staff
UP Police Constable Exam	2024	Uttar pradesh	Whatsapp Group circulated question paper before exams , 48 lakh students effected	-UPPSC suspended officials -20+ arrests made -Massive protests made
UGC-NET	2024	Nationwide	Question paper leaked and Exam integrity was compromised,More than 9 lakh people were affected	-NTA under investigation -Supreme Court petition -15+ Arrests made -Students Protested for 15 days
CBSE 10 & 12	2018	Nationwide	Mathematics and Economics paper was leaked before. More than 2 million Students got effceted	-Public Outrage -CBSE actions against Officials -10+ Arrests made -New security protocols were implemented -Electronic surveillance implemented
SSC CGL	2017	Multiple states	Massive Leaks , More than 16 lakh people were affected , WIde spread of protest	- Re-exam conducted - SSC security tightened - Officials suspended - Massive student protests nationwide
REET (Rajasthan Teacher Exam)	2021	Rajasthan	Question paper leaked before exam; teaching aspirants affected	- 15+ arrests made - RPSC officials suspended - New security measures implemented - Rajasthan High Court reviewed the case
BPSC 67th CCE	2022	Bihar	Preliminary exam paper leaked and circulated on social media	- BPSC officials suspended - 10+ arrests made - Security protocols revised - Bihar government promised better monitoring

The table given above shows that major exams such as SSC , NEET and other examinations has affected more than 50 million people in just past 8 years. Beside that the Government has also put many financial Resources in Reconducting and cancelling the exams. The Re exam cost data for every exam is given below:-

PAPER NAME	NUMBER OF CANDIDIATES	RE EXAM COST
NEET-UG 2026	22.79 LAKH	300 - 400 CR
NEET-UG 2024	20.8 LAKH	100 CR
UP CONSTABLE EXAM	48 LAKH	50-60 CR
UGC NET	9 LAKH	25-30 CR
CBSE CLASS 10& 12	20 LAKH	50 CR
SSC CGL	16 LAKH	40 CR
REET	2.5 LAKH	15 CR
BPSE	7.5 LAKH	8-10 CR

Table-2: Candidates Affected and Estimated Re-examination Cost

The above table gives us the data of cost of every Re exam , So the total of the Government cost would be 650-750 cr for Re conducting the past 5 years Leaks and total economic cost (including household burden,coaching and other issues faced by students and govt cost) would be around 1500-2000 cr for the past 5 years leaks.

1.5 Legal Provisions on Education and Examination Leaks

- **1.5.1 Constitution of India**

1. ***Article 21A - Right to Education:***

Free and compulsory education for children from 6-14 years old. Fundamental rights compromised by Repeated paper leaks.

2. ***Article 14/15(1) - Equality before law/No discrimination on basis of anything:***

Paper leaks Violates equal opportunities for all candidates.Leaks also discriminates the Candidates who are genuine and has worked hard for the examination

3. ***Article 41 -Public assistance for Right To Education***

mandates the State to provide public assistance for the right to education, establishing the government's constitutional duty to ensure fair and accessible examinations.

- **1.5.2 Major Acts and Laws**

1. ***Public Examinations (prevention of Unfair means) Act,2024***

Passed by lok sabha - February 5 , 2024

Come in effect - June 21 , 2024

Covers - UPSC ,SSC ,RAILWAY RECRUITMENT BOARD ,IBPS , NEET ,JEE ,CUET ,STATE PSCs

- aims to prevent examination leaks and unfair practices. It prescribes punishments for offenses such as leaking question papers, impersonation, tampering, assisting in cheating, hacking, and other malpractices. Depending on the nature of the offense, penalties range from 3 to 10 years of imprisonment and fines from ₹10 lakh to ₹1 crore.

2. ***Uttar Pradesh Examination (Prevention of Unfair means) Ordinance, 2024(State Law- Harsher)***

Passed - 2024

Punishment:-

- Life Imprisonment for paper leaks Causing Exam cancellation
- Fine up to 1 crore
- Minimum 2 Years for distributing fake papers
- Recovery of exam expense from solver gang

3. ***Right of children To Free and Compulsory Education act, 2009***

Enacted: August 4,2009

Come into Force: April 1,2010

Enforced under: Article 21A

This Act aims to make education a fundamental right and India has joined 135 Countries with education as fundamental right. Paper Leaks violates the spirit of equitable education

4. ***Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita(BNS), 2023***

Replaced- Indian Penal Code(IPC) 18,60

Sections Relevant:

- Section 231 - Cheating by personation (1-3 years imprisonment)
- Section 232 - Forgery (2 years imprisonment)

- **1.5.3 International Conventions and Treaties**

1. ***UNESCO Global Convention On Recognition of Qualification***

Adopted - November 25,2019

Purpose - Promote quality assurance and academic integrity Globally

It aims to uphold academic integrity in higher education by eradicating fraudulent practices related to qualifications, fostering trust and confidence in the quality of qualifications, promoting integrity and ethical practices, and utilizing contemporary technologies to prevent fraud and ensure authenticity

2. ***UN Convention Against Corruption (UNCAC), 2003***

India Signed: December 2003

Article 13: Promote public awareness about corruption threats

Article 14: Education programs in schools/universities against corruption

2. METHODOLOGY

This study adopts a Descriptive and Analytical method of research Through Survey of the Impact of politics and governance on education.

This Study was based on two main sources of data: primary and secondary data

2.1 Primary Data

The primary data was collected directly from respondents using a structure google form designed by the authors

The survey was mainly targeted to the students of Grade 11th and 12th, College students, parents and employees

Approximately 100 people participated in the survey with giving their different inputs for the each and every questions

The survey was a form with structured questionnaire with each question being Multiple Choice Question on awareness of paper leaks, trust in exams, opinion on political influence and views on fairness of re examination

The survey was conducted online through Google forms to ensure easy access of everyone. The survey link was shared through Whatsapp, Instagram , School/Colleges group and other networks.

2.2 Secondary Data

The secondary data was collected from differents Existing means relevant to leaks and education in india

The secondary data sources included:-

- Government Documents
- Official Statistics and Reports
- News Article (NDTV , Hindu , Economic times ,Times of India)
- Policy Analysis and Reports

Secondary data was to quantify and to support the arguments and views of the primary survey findings

The combination of primary and secondary data allows the study to capture both real student perspectives and documented national-level trends.

3. RESULT

The result is divided into two parts - Primary Data Results and Secondary Data Results

3.1 Primary Data Results

Primary Data results are based on the Google Forms containing Question regarding impact of politics on education to get a knowledge about how the people think toward it.

The form was based on MCQs and was spread amongst 80 people with there responses given below with the questions

Q1 - What is your Profession ?

Answer-The majority of the respondents (approximately 62%) were school students. College students were around 15–17% of the participants, while the remaining respondents were working professionals and homemakers.

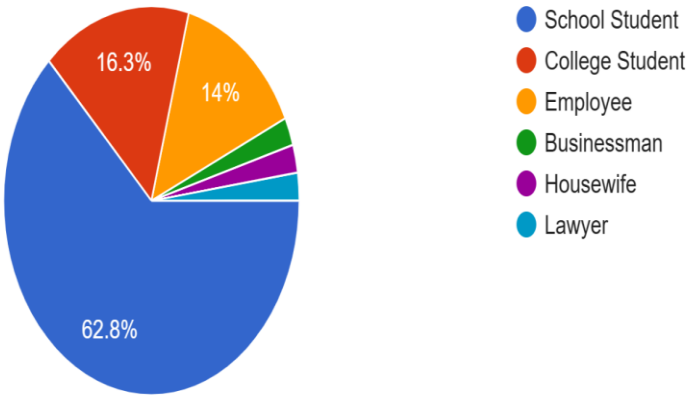


Fig-1: Profession of Survey Respondents

Q2- How do you think exam paper leaks affect the education system in India?

Answer- A vast majority of respondents (86%) believed that examination paper leaks severely damage the credibility and fairness of the education system. The remaining 14% stated that such incidents moderately affect students' trust in the system.

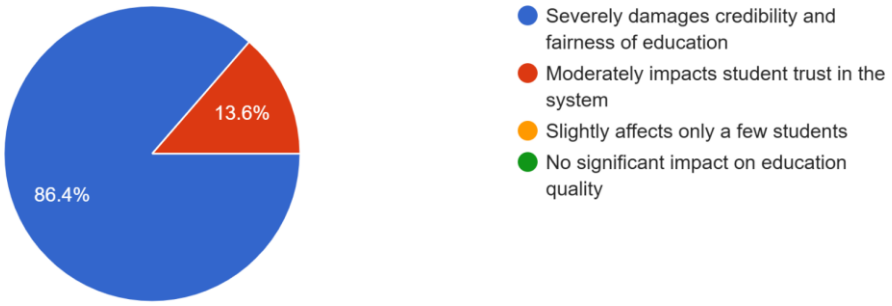


Fig-2: Perceived Effect of Paper Leaks on the Education System

Q3- Do you believe political influence contributes to exam paper leaks in examinations?

Answer- Approx 68% responses has marked Yes definitely. Approx 21 % responses believes there's some involvement of politics and approx 11% believe's Maybe

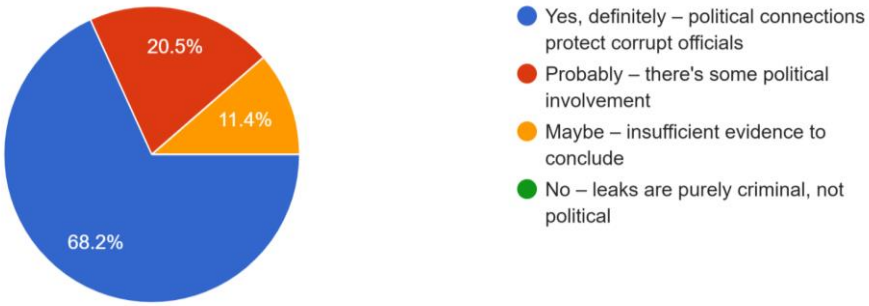


Fig-3: Perceived Contribution of Political Influence to Paper Leaks

Q4- what should be the primary solution to prevent exam paper leaks ? (In this question the responder can choose more than 1 option)

Answer- 75% of the respondents believe Better security protocols for question paper creation. Approx.59 % of the responder said Stronger legal penalties for those involved .Approx 40% responded Political accountability for examination bodies. And only 13.6% Responder said for Digital Examinations

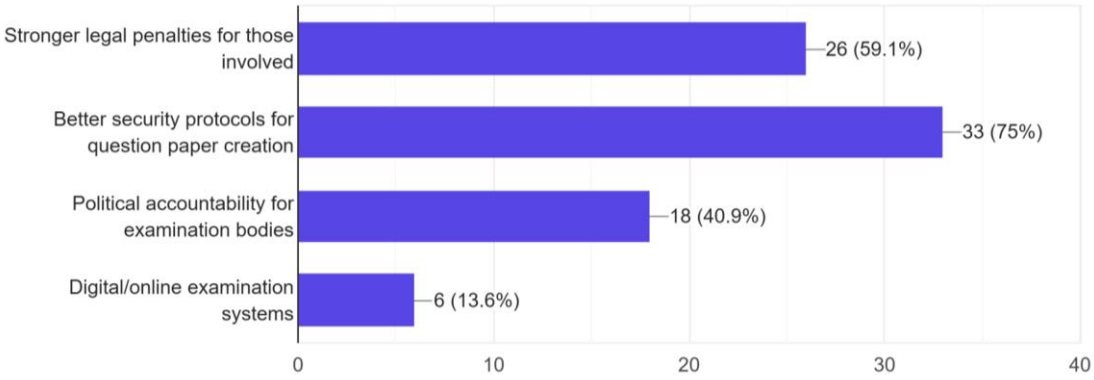


Fig-4: Preferred Primary Solutions to Prevent Paper Leaks

Q6 - Do you believe paper leaks mostly happens due to corruption in Government

Answer- More than half of the respondents (54%) agreed that corruption within the government is a major cause of examination paper leaks, while 30% strongly agreed with this view. Around 10% remained neutral, and the remaining respondents disagreed.



Fig-5: Perceived Role of Government Corruption in Paper Leaks

Q7- Should exams with confirmed paper leaks be cancelled and re-conducted nationwide?

Answer- 52.3% of the responder believe that yes and it is always fair for all candidates.Another 29.5% supported reconducting examinations only when the leaks are widespread or systemic .13.6% of responder believe to only cancel affected regions and remaining believes that re conducting create more problems

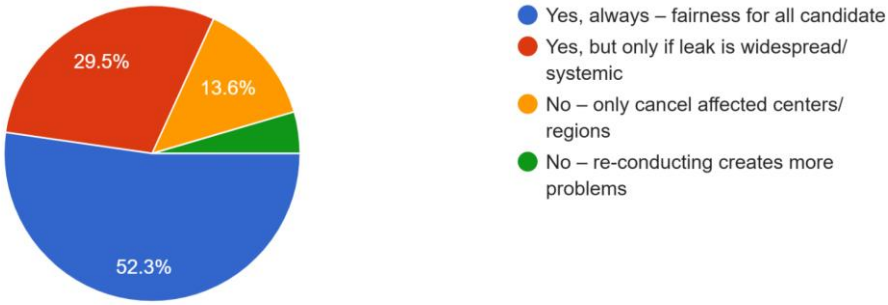


Fig-6: Views on Cancellation and Nationwide Re-conduct of Leaked Examinations

Q8- How would you rate government response to paper leak in past 5 years?

Answer- Approx 45% Responder has rated Not good While 41% rated Very bad and has done nothing. Approx 13% has rated good and out of which 7% has believe that Government has taken best steps

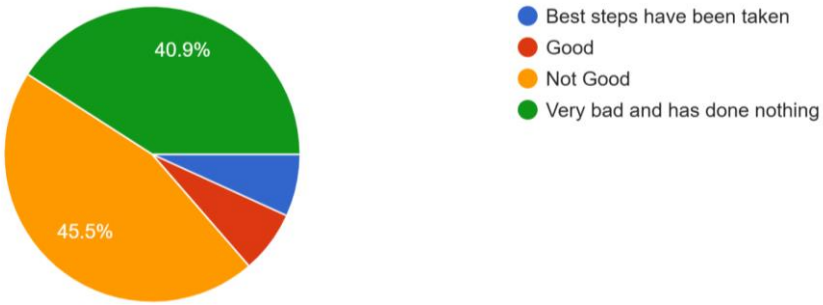


Fig-7: Rating of Government Response to Paper Leaks Over the Past Five Years

Q9- What is your opinion regarding On-Screen Marking (OSM) and digital evaluation systems?

Answer- About 31.8% of respondents rated them negatively, and 22.7% considered them very ineffective. Another 31.8% remained neutral, while 9.1% viewed them as effective and 4.5% regarded them as highly effective.

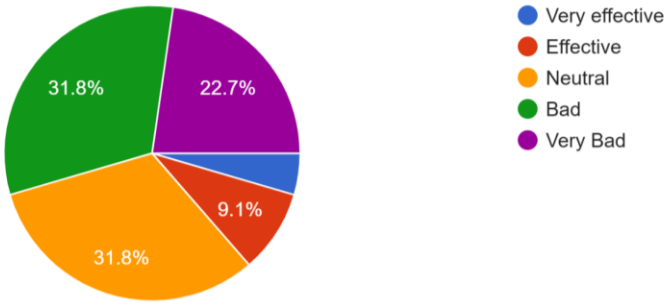


Fig-8: Opinion on On-Screen Marking and Digital Evaluation Systems

Q10-Do you agree that the Government should establish a permanent and independent examination agency to protect exam leaks with its own infrastructure instead of relying on private contractors and tenders?

Answer- Most of the people believed had agree on that except for 2.3% responder did not agree

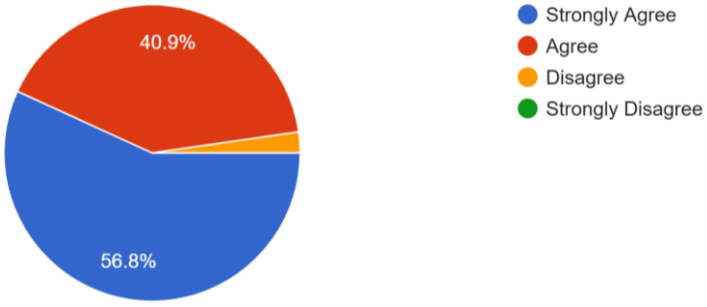


Fig-9: Support for a Permanent Independent Examination Authority

Based on the responses received, participants largely perceive examination paper leaks as a serious threat to the fairness and credibility of India's education system. Most respondents believe that political influence and governmental corruption contribute significantly to such incidents and are dissatisfied with the government's response over the past five years. They strongly advocate for enhanced security protocols, stricter legal action against offenders, and greater accountability in examination bodies. Furthermore, respondents overwhelmingly support the creation of a permanent and independent examination agency with its own infrastructure to ensure transparency, security, and public trust in the examination process.

3.2 Secondary Data Results

The analysis of secondary data reveals that examination paper leaks have become a recurring challenge affecting the integrity of India's education and recruitment systems. Data collected from government reports, news articles, policy documents, and previous research studies indicate that several major examinations, including NEET-UG, UGC-NET, SSC CGL, UP Police Constable, REET, and BPSC examinations, have faced incidents of paper leaks and examination malpractice during the past decade.

The findings show that these incidents have affected millions of candidates across the country. Examination leaks not only compromise fairness and merit but also result in large financial costs for governments due to the need for re-examinations, enhanced security arrangements, and investigation procedures. Based on available estimates, the combined cost of re-conducting major examinations in recent years has amounted to several hundred crores of rupees. In addition, students and families face indirect economic losses through coaching expenses, travel costs, accommodation expenses, and lost preparation time.

The secondary data further indicate that governance weaknesses, inadequate security systems, corruption networks, and poor accountability mechanisms are common factors behind examination leaks. Despite the existence of legal provisions and disciplinary actions, enforcement has often been delayed or inconsistent. Studies and reports also highlight that public trust in examination authorities declines significantly after major leak incidents.

Recent legislative measures such as the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 demonstrate increased governmental efforts to address the problem. However, evidence suggests that stronger implementation, technological safeguards, transparent administration, and institutional accountability are necessary to prevent future incidents. Overall, the secondary data support the argument that examination malpractice is not merely an educational issue but also a governance challenge that requires comprehensive policy reforms and stronger institutional mechanisms

3.3 Limitations of the Study

This study has certain limitations. The primary survey was conducted among approximately 100 respondents, with a majority being students, which may not fully represent the views of the entire population. The study relied partly on secondary data obtained from

news reports, government documents, and existing research, whose findings may vary over time. Due to time and resource constraints, it was not possible to examine every examination leak case in India. Therefore, the findings should be interpreted as indicative rather than exhaustive.

3.4 Recommendations

i. To establish an permanent autonomous examination body to protect Paper leaks with its own infrastructure and security system to reduce the independence on private contactors

ii. Secure the question paper digitally by end to end encryption and a 24/7 centralised IT team to make sure that paper are held well and there is no problem like done in CUET

iii. Expand the Use of Technology such as AI-based monitoring systems, biometric verification, secure digital tracking, and surveillance mechanisms to detect irregularities.

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v. Precaution should be taken before the examination and usage of forces like air force, army should be taken for transferring the paper

4. CONCLUSION

The study has examined the impact of politics and governance on the education system of India through both primary and secondary data. The results show us that examination leaks have emerged serious year by year. Incidents involving paper leaks of NEET 2024 and 2026, SSC , UGC-NET has shown that paper leak is a recurring issue and has affected millions of people

The primary Data has Revealed has Shown that majority of the respondents has believe that paper leaks severely damages the integrity and system. They also believe that there is a strong influence of politics on paper leaks and there has a major role of corruption in it. It has revealed that they believe that government has done almost nothing in past 5 years against paper leak

Secondary data show that paper leaks cause educational unfairness, financial losses, and reduced public trust in examination systems. Repeated leaks weaken meritocracy and equal opportunity while imposing significant costs on students, families, and the government.

In conclusion, protecting examination integrity is essential for preserving public trust, ensuring fair competition, and strengthening India's educational system. A secure and transparent examination framework will not only benefit students but also contribute to the broader goals of social justice, good governance, and national development.

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